Exchange

By Ray Bradbury

INTRODUCTION

There is only one form of magic in the world: reading. Think about it for a moment. Reading can transport you to places you've never been and never will go. It can be your best friend and your escape from realities that are too difficult to manage. If there is any gift I could pass on to my own kids, it would be this one. Teaching them that reading is magic–true magic–and that libraries are the sanctuaries where you learn that magic. They are places where newcomers can be introduced to the magic, and old-timers can revel in it, one page at a time. Here, let me show you . . Exchange by Ray Bradbury.

There were too many cards in the file, too many books on the shelves, too many children laughing in the children's room, too many newspapers to fold and stash on the racks. . .

Finally the last book was stamped, the last child fed through the great brass doors, and with immense weariness, Miss Adams moved back through a silence of forty years of books and being

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keeper of the books, and stood for a long moment by the main desk. Taking up her rubber stamp, she probed the files, weeding out errors, her fingers whispering between Dante and Darwin.

A moment later she heard the rapping on the front-door glass and saw a man's shadow outside, wanting in. Sighing, Miss Adams opened the door, saw a young man in uniform, and said, "It's late. We're closed." She glanced at his insignia and added, "Captain."

"Hold on!" said the captain. "Remember me?" And repeated it, as she hesitated. "Remember?"

She studied his face, trying to bring light out of shadow. "Yes, I think I do," she said at last. "You once borrowed books here. Many years ago."

"May I come in?"

She hesitated, [then] led the way up the steps into the immense twilight of books. The young officer looked around and let his breath out slowly,

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then reached to take a book and hold it to his nose, inhaling, then almost laughing.

"Don't mind me, Miss Adams. You ever smell new books? Binding, pages, print. Like fresh bread when you're hungry." His eyes were troubled and he fretted his cap, turning it in his long, slender fingers.

She said gently, "Is anything wrong? Anything I can help you with?"

He glanced out the window at the dark town, with just a few lights in the windows of the small houses across the way. "I was surprised. I don't know what I expected. Pretty dumb to expect that when I went away, everyone froze in place waiting for me to come home. That when I stepped off the train, all my old pals would unfreeze, run down, meet me at the station. Silly."

"Did anyone know you were coming?" she asked.

"I wrote a few, but no answers. I figured,

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they're busy, but they'll be there. They weren't."

"I'm still here," she said.

"You are," he said with a quick smile. "And I can't tell you how glad I am."

"You know," she said, "I must confess you look familiar, but I don't quite fit your face with the boy who came here-"

"Twenty years ago! And as for what he looked like, that other one, me, well-" He brought out a wallet and handed over a photograph of a boy perhaps twelve years old, with an impish smile and wild blond hair, looking as if he might catapult out of the frame.

"Ah, yes." Miss Adams closed her eyes to remember. "Spaulding. William Henry Spaulding?"

"Was I a lot of trouble?"

"Yes." She nodded and held the picture closer and glanced up at him. "A fiend." She handed the picture back. "But I loved you."

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"Did you?" he said and smiled more broadly.

"In spite of you, yes. A good question. Let's not stand like your frozen friends. Come along. Take off that coat. The file index is there. Go look up your old library cards."

He stood staring down into the index file like a bird fixing its gaze on a half-empty nest. He handed her one of the old purple-stamped cards. "I took out a lot of books."

"Ten at a time. I said no, but you took them. And read them!"

"Over here, of course, is the adult section."

"I begged you to let me cross over when I was thirteen. 'You're not ready,' you said. But-"

"I let you cross over anyway?"

"I hope you won't be upset, but when I was a boy I used to look up and see you behind your desk, so near but far away, and, how can I say this, I used to think that you were Mrs. God, and that

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the library was a whole world, and that no matter what part of the world or what people or thing I wanted to see and read, you'd find and give it to me . . . You did, too. You had the world ready for me every time I asked. There was always a place I hadn't seen, a country I hadn't visited where you took me. I've never forgotten."

She looked around, slowly, at the thousands of books. She felt her heart move quietly. "Did you really call me what you just said?"

"Mrs. God? Oh, yes. Often. Always." He suddenly leaned against the banister, holding tight. "Miss Adams." He exhaled. "I'm scared. I don't want to leave. I'm afraid. I don't want to go away without saying good-bye. If I never return, I want to see all my friends . . . But I walk around town and nobody knows me. Everyone's gone."

Miss Adams took his arm and guided him to a brightly decorated room. "Do you realize

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Thomas Wolfe was wrong?"

"Wolfe? The great literary beast? Wrong?"

"The title of one of his books."

"You Can't Go Home Again?" he guessed.

"That's it. He was wrong. This is home. Your friends are still here. This was your summer place."

"Yes. Myths. Legends. Mummies. Aztec kings. Wicked sisters who spat toads. Where I really lived. But I don't see my people."

She switched on a green-shaded lamp that shed a private light on a small table. "Isn't this nice? Most libraries today, too much light. There should be shadows, don't you think? Some mystery, yes? So that late nights the beasts can prowl out of the stacks and crouch by this jungle light to turn the pages with their breath. Am I crazy?"

She vanished into the stacks and came out with ten books that she placed upright, their pages a trifle spread so they could stand and he could

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read the titles.

"The summer of 1930, when you were, what? ten, you read all of these in one week."

"Oz? Dorothy? The Wizard? Oh, yes."

She placed still others nearby.

"Alice in Wonderland. Through the Looking-Glass; Tarzan of the Apes; John Carter, Warlord of Mars. Dear lady, how come you remember all this?"

"You never left. Summertimes you were here when I unlocked the doors. You sometimes brought sandwiches and sat out by the stone lion at noon. Your father pulled you home by your ear some nights when you stayed late. How could I forget a boy like that? You never played, never ran out in baseball weather, or football. Why?"

He glanced toward the front door. "They were waiting for me . . . You know. The ones who never borrowed books, never read. They. Them. Those."

"It's a wonder you survived. I used to watch

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you reading hunchbacked late afternoons. You looked so lonely."

"No. I had these. Company."

"Here's more." She put down Ivanhoe, Robin Hood, and Treasure Island. She came out not carrying many books but one at a time, as if each one were, indeed, special. She began to make a circle and as she placed the books, in lonely splendor, he said their names and then the names of the authors who had written them. She placed the first book and someone, far away, called "Kathy" a girl he had walked to school in the sixth grade [was] seated across the table.

A second book was set in place and another girl [appeared], who hid behind the book and dared to pass him notes when he was twelve.

And then [the girl] who always skirted the outer rim of school and went to swim in the deep lake ten thousand afternoons ago and never came out, so

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was never found, but suddenly now she made landfall here in the green-shaded light and opened Yeats.

And on her right: John Huff, whose name came clearer than the rest, who claimed to have climbed every tree in town and fallen from none, who yodeled at your sun-up window and wrote the same Mark Twain book report in four different grades.

And next to him was yet another girl.

And next to her ...

And just beyond ...

And it was finished, all the books were placed. He sat for a long moment and then, one by one, opened them and read. Behind him, he heard the lady librarian quietly back away to leave him with words.

A long while later he sat back, rubbed his yes, and looked around at the fortress of books, and

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nodded, his eyes wet.

"Yes . . . Thomas Wolfe, the title of that book of his. Wrong. Everything's here. Nothing's changed."

"Nothing will as long as I can help it . . . she said. Just then, from below the town, a train whistle blew. "Is that yours?"

"No, but the one soon after," he said and got up and moved around the small monuments that stood very tall and one by one, shut the covers, his lips moving to sound the old titles and the old, dear names. Do we have to put them back on the shelves?"

She looked at him and after a long moment said, "Tomorrow will do. Why?"

"Maybe during the night, because of the color of those lamps, green, the jungle, maybe those creatures you mentioned will come out and turn the pages with their breath. And maybe . . . Maybe

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my friends, who've hid in the stacks all these years, will come out, too."

"They're already here." She backed off across the room without making any sound, and when she reached her desk she called back, the last call of the night. "Closing time. Closing time, children." And turned the lights quickly off and then on and then halfway between; a library twilight.

He moved from the table with the double circle of books and came to her and said, "I can go now."

"Yes, William Henry Spaulding. You can

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